Giving a senior corporate lawyer and pro bono leader the capacity to build her own AI agents



Melissa Hollatz, 25+ year corporate and M&A partner at Wilson Sonsini, now Senior Counsel leading the Nonprofit Protection Project at the Law Foundation of Silicon Valley

2	3	hours → minutes
ONE-HOUR SESSIONS	AGENTS SHE BUILT HERSELF	PER POLICY REVIEW

Context

Melissa leads the Nonprofit Protection Project, which gives practical legal help to nonprofits. Demand keeps growing, and Melissa's time and case capacity set the limit on how many organizations the project can reach.

The Belltower approach: real needs, existing tools

We started with Melissa's actual needs and built solutions using tools the Law Foundation already licensed wherever possible.

- **Agents for scalable legal work:** whistleblower, conflict-of-interest, and bylaws reviews.
- **Conveniences that connect the dots and make things work:** drafting client emails summarizing the legal review, summaries of policies for clients, and case-management update emails.
- **Existing tools:** a Microsoft Form that captures volunteer participation and estimated hours for audit and data reporting. Not AI or new software, but rather getting value out of something they already pay for.

Results

- **Fast:** from nearly zero AI use to three working agents after two one-hour sessions in a three-week period.
- **We give capacity, not a webinar:** we build the scaffolding and Melissa builds the agents herself.
- **Deepened Legal Expertise:** the agents apply her standards rather than replace them, so her hours go further and are spent on the highest-leverage points of exercising judgment (vs. first-draft redlining).
- **Time and increased ambition:** many hours saved each week, so the Law Foundation can serve more clients and Melissa has space to expand the project.

What's next

We're moving from our first project at the Law Foundation to helping scale this approach across several of its Pro Bono projects.

IN HER WORDS

"I started with Belltower Partners as an AI beginner and couldn't have imagined how much they have been able to do. Within just a couple of 1-hour sessions, they coached me to the point where I could build, test, and improve my own agents. My first few have streamlined multiple projects allowing us to serve more clients. And Belltower Partners continues to find innovative ways to help me better leverage my time and expertise to expand my client base and capabilities.

Shawn and Uday are talented, intuitive, and patient teachers who helped me level up. ***They don't just help me use AI, they help me use AI in a way that harnesses my experience to create a tool that's customized to reflect my judgement and expertise.*** *Shawn's background as an attorney is especially helpful.*

I recommend them whole-heartedly."

— Melissa Hollatz